



MYPRAYERS · CONCEPT NOTE

Presence at a Distance

Being there for someone when you **can't be there** — and letting them feel it. The count isn't a score. It's the answer to **“how many people are holding me right now?”**

- Proposal, not a spec
 - Supersedes the counter framing
 - Prototype: myprayers/index.html
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01 The problem

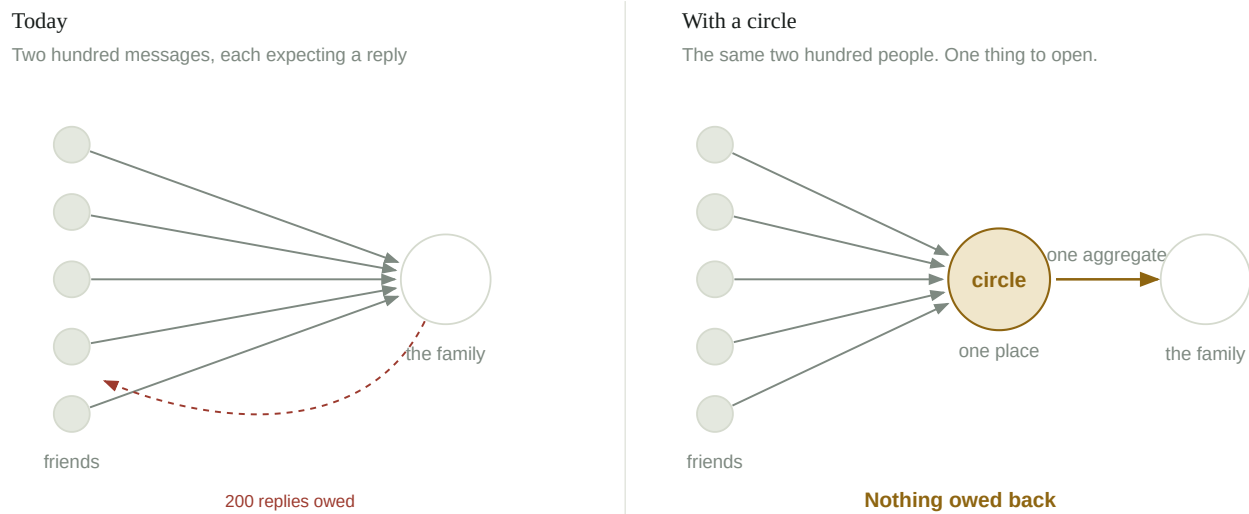
Something bad happens to someone you love. You're in another city, another country, or simply not welcome in the hospital corridor. You can't do anything — but doing nothing feels unbearable.

So you send a message. *Praying for you* 🙏. And so do two hundred other people.

Here is what that looks like from the other side. Every message that arrives is a small **debt**. Each one expects an answer, and the family is at the exact moment in their lives when they have the least capacity to give one. Many stop opening their phone at all.

So the well-wishers feel unheard, and the family feels buried under love they cannot process. Both sides lose.

FIGURE 1



The difference is the **return arrows**. Today every act of care creates an obligation for the person least able to meet it. A circle keeps the care and removes the obligation.

Everyone gets to be present. Nobody has to reply.

That is the product. Not counting prayers — **converting a flood of individually-demanding messages into one aggregate that asks nothing back.**

02 Three people, not one

The prototype had one role: someone who prays. The real thing has three, and the second one is the reason the product exists.

The one who acts

Can't be there. Needs to do something rather than nothing, and needs that something to actually land. Today their only option is a message that adds to the pile.

The one who is held

Going through it. Needs to feel that family, friends and community are close — all of them, at once. Needs it without cost: no replies,

no thanking two hundred people, no performance of gratitude while exhausted.

The world

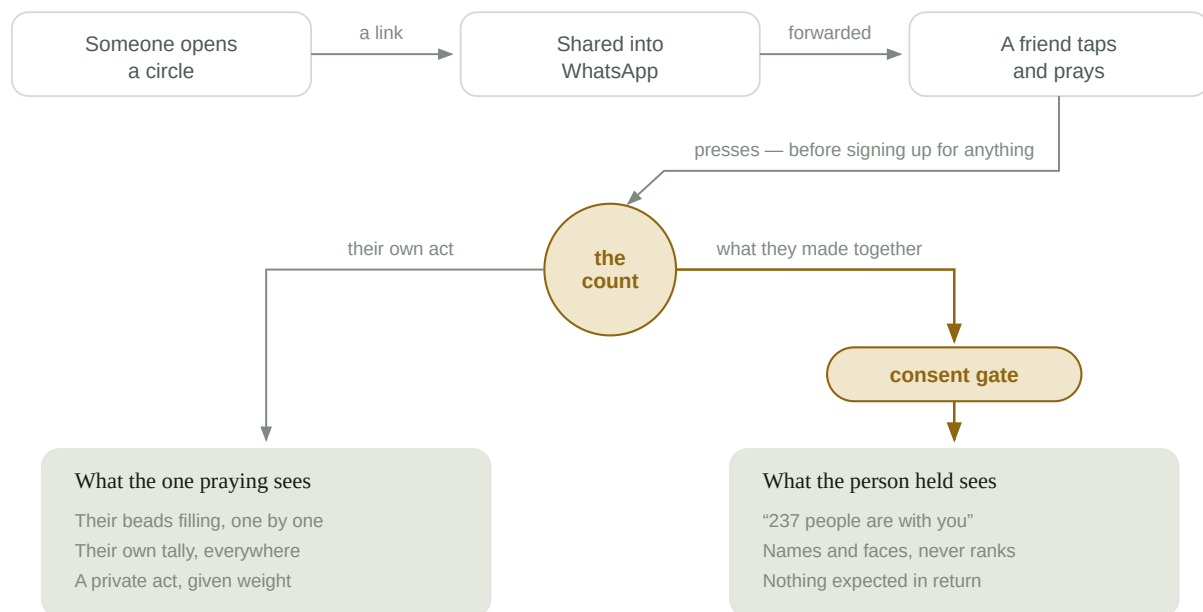
Floods in Nepal. A war. An earthquake. Strangers who want to direct something toward it. This is real, and it's also how people find you — but it isn't where the value is.

03 How it works

One press. Two completely different outputs, for two people who need opposite things.

The person praying needs to feel they *did* something — so they get their own beads, their own count, a private act with weight to it. The person being held needs the opposite: not a number to admire, but the knowledge that **these named people** are with them, and that none of them wants anything back.

FIGURE 2



The same press produces **two different truths**. Only the right-hand path touches a vulnerable person, so only that path is gated.

04 The hard constraint: consent

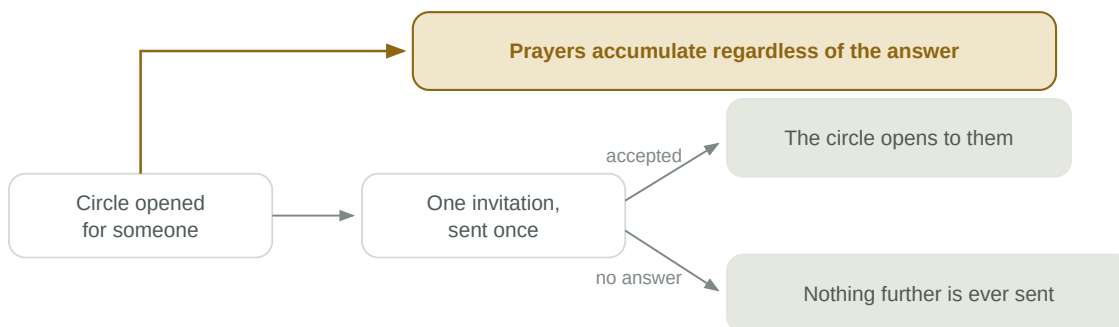
You cannot make a page about a named sick person and notify them. Someone discovering a "pray for their recovery" page could be

devastated — they may not have told anyone, may not believe, may not want it. This is the single biggest way this product could hurt someone.

But recipient-initiated-only would kill it, because the entire point is **a friend acting when the person can't**.

The resolution is to separate *accumulating* from *delivering*. The circle always works. It just never reaches anyone uninvited.

FIGURE 3



Accumulating and delivering are separate. A circle for someone in an ICU still fills up — **a family member can accept on their behalf**, and the person themselves may never need to open it at all.

A RELATED CALL

The person being held probably shouldn't need an account. A link they open at the worst moment of their life, with no signup — lowest friction exactly where it matters most.

05 The moment

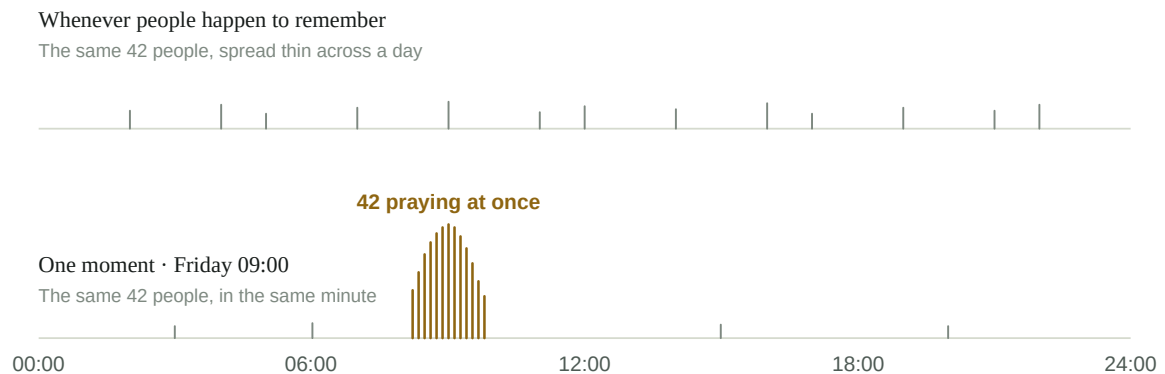
"Meera's surgery is Friday at 9. Pray with us at 9."

Everyone gets one nudge. At nine o'clock the screen says **42 people are praying right now** — live, together. Then it's over.

This is what real communities have always done: a vigil, a novena, a *dua* at a set hour. And it is the one thing a digital version does **better** than the physical one, because it can gather people across twelve time zones into the same minute.

It also gives the family something a running total never can — a moment they can point to and remember.

FIGURE 4



Same people, same day, same number of prayers. **Concentration is the whole product.** Scattered attention is invisible; forty-two people in the same minute is an event.

IF YOU KEEP ONE FEATURE BEYOND THE BUTTON

Make it this. It converts a counter into an event, and an event is something people show up for, tell others about, and remember afterwards.

06 How a circle ends

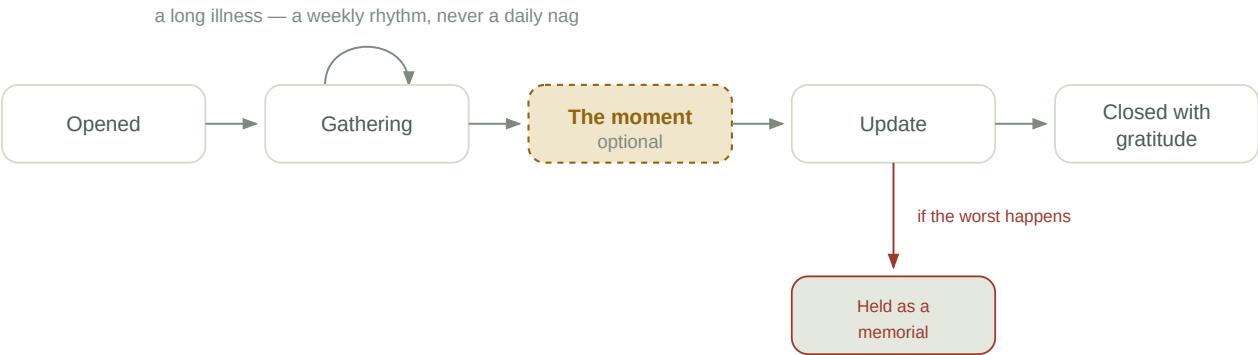
Events resolve, and a circle that doesn't end **rots**. Silence starts to read as bad news; people who came to help end up anxious instead of comforted. So closure isn't a nicety — it's load-bearing.

And you must design for the outcome nobody wants to design for.

Someone will die. Probably in your first month. The circle has to become a memorial or close with dignity — it must never just go quiet, and it must never send “*keep praying!*” to a bereaved family.

Get this right and people will trust you with the most important moments of their lives. Get it wrong once and that's the story that travels.

FIGURE 5

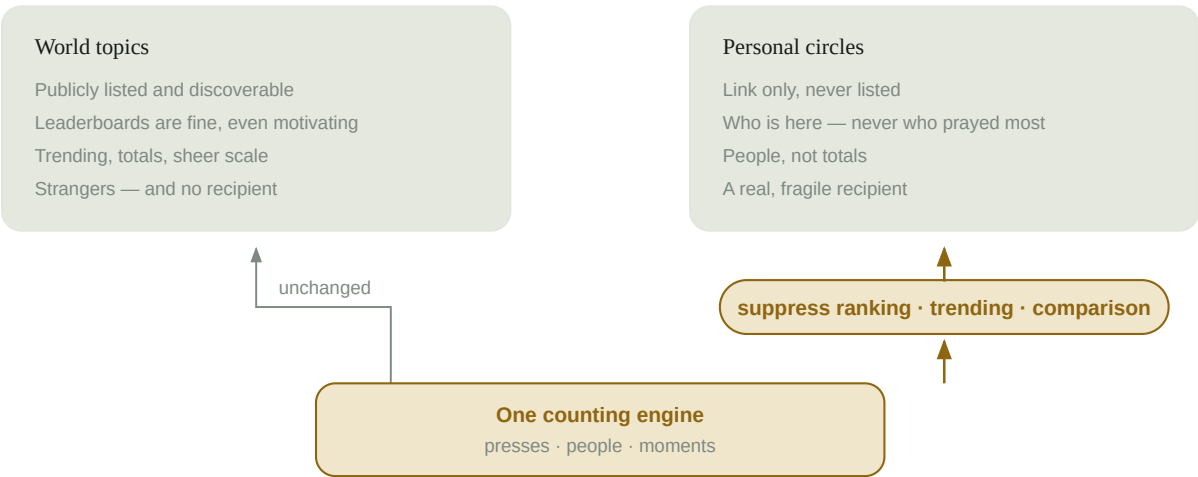


Every circle has a **designed ending**, including the one you hope never comes. A circle that simply stops posting is the failure mode.

07 Two modes, one engine

World topics and personal circles run on the same counting engine, but they are not the same product and must not look like it. The personal surface is defined as much by what it **refuses to show** as by what it shows.

FIGURE 6



The filter is the design. Everything the world surface celebrates — ranks, trends, comparison — becomes **cruelty** when the subject is somebody's dying father.

	WORLD TOPIC	PERSONAL CIRCLE
Subject	An event	A person
Discovery	Public, listed, searchable	Link only — never listed
Who joins	Strangers	Your actual people
The count means	Scale of attention	Depth of love
Headline number	Prayers offered	People with you
Recipient	Nobody	A real, fragile human
Retention driver	The news cycle	The relationship
Role in the business	The storefront	The reason to exist

Where world topics come from

If anyone can open one you get “Nepal floods” forty times over. Let users **propose**; you approve and merge duplicates. The curation is also your editorial voice.

WRITE THIS RULE DOWN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Someone will open “*pray for victory for ____*”. A conflict topic splits your user base and makes you a target. The rule: **world topics name human suffering, never a side**. “For civilians in ____”, not “for victory for ____”. Far easier to apply if it was written in calm weather.

08 Rules we don't break

Each of these is a specific way this product could hurt the person it's meant to serve.

✗ No leaderboard in a personal circle

“Most prayers offered” for someone's dying father turns grief into a competition. Show who is here, not who prayed most.

- ✗ **Never rank circles against each other**
If six people pray for your mother and four thousand for a stranger's, the comparison is cruel. No trending, no “popular circles”.

- ✗ **Never reach a recipient uninvited**
One invitation, once. Silence is an answer, and it means stop.

- ✗ **Never nudge a bereaved family**
The moment a circle becomes a memorial, every automated prompt stops.

- ✗ **Nobody is asked to pray to anything but their own**
Each person addresses the divine they hold. The atheist friend gets to be present without pretending.

- ✗ **Religion is never attached to a name in public**
Belief plus a phone number is sensitive data in every jurisdiction that matters. Tradition stays optional and unattributed by default.

That last pair is also the differentiator. Almost every prayer app is single-faith. An interfaith one where a Hindu, a Muslim and someone who believes in nothing all show up for the same sick child — **that isn't a feature, it's the reason the thing exists.**

09 What v1 is

Cut to the thing that produces the feeling. The public wall, discovery, streaks, malas and profiles are all secondary — they're the counter product, and the counter product is not the point.

In

- Open a circle for someone — what's happening, and when the moment is
- Share to WhatsApp
- Land, press, pray — before signing up for anything
- Leave *one line*, optionally
- The recipient view, consented: names, presence, no reply expected
- The synchronised moment
- Update, and close well

Later

- Public world topics and discovery
- Curation and merge tooling
- Streaks, malas, personal history
- Persistent circles (a family, a parish)
- Accounts with recovery
- Push notifications at scale

And rename it. “Topic” is wrong for a person. A world event is a *topic*; a person is a *circle*, or a *vigil*. In an emotional product the noun does real work.

10 Still open

Do notes create a new reply-debt?

People will want to say something, and the family will re-read those lines for years. But a wall of notes can quietly become another 200 things to answer. Proposal: notes are collected, never delivered individually, and there is no reply affordance anywhere.

Who can close a circle?

The creator opened it, but the family lives it. Proposal: creator by default, transferable to a family contact on request.

Does the recipient see the number at all?

Names may be kinder than a count when the count is small.
Proposal: show faces first, and the number only once it's past a floor.

How do we re-engage without WhatsApp Business API?

Web push is unreliable on iOS, and template messages are paid, pre-approved and easy to get flagged. Proposal for v1: web push where available, plus a manual “nudge the group” that re-shares to WhatsApp. Manual nudging costs nothing and is culturally normal.

MyPrayers concept note · drafted from the product discussion · a proposal for review, not a specification. The working prototype at myprayers/index.html implements the counting engine only — the recipient view, consent, the moment and closure are all still to be designed.